

A 7-WEEK HOME-SCHOOL SUMMER

SUMMER  
BUILD LAB

# Reznor's *Build Lab*

Seven weeks of learning that doesn't feel like school — built on how the best countries in the world actually teach their youngest kids. Less drilling, more making. He's the inventor; you're the lab partner.

Play & movement first

Math you can hold

Coding before screens

~3–5 hrs/week of "school"

EN + ES

START HERE

## How to run this

### Five rules for the grown-ups

- ♦ **Follow his energy, not the clock.** A great morning sprint is 30–45 minutes. When his interest fades, you're done — stop on a high note.
- ♦ **No tests, no grades, no worksheets.** The whole edge here is that it's the opposite of school. If it starts to feel like a chore, change it.
- ♦ **Skip and swap freely.** Filming days, Reznor commitments, lazy beach days — move things around. Missing a day costs nothing.
- ♦ **His four activities ARE the curriculum.** Drums, hip hop, swim, taekwondo = the movement foundation everything else sits on. Don't cut them for "school."
- ♦ **Protect boredom and free play.** Don't fill every gap. Unstructured time is where the inventing actually happens.

## THE 5 THREADS

# What you're weaving

### **Make & Build**

#### THE SPINE OF THE SUMMER

One big project he chews on for 7 weeks: invent a board game, then rebuild it on a screen. Hits art, writing, math & coding at once.

### **Lego Math**

#### SINGAPORE METHOD

Math you can hold: real objects first, then pictures, then numbers. "Show me with bricks" before any symbol. No worksheets.

### **Coding**

#### ESTONIA METHOD

Start screen-free — the Sandwich Robot, Lego-by-instruction, arrow mazes. Then graduate to ScratchJr on the iPad.

### **Reading EN + ES**

#### KEEP BOTH LADDERS CLIMBING

He already flies here — so go deeper & wider, not faster. One stretch book always going, and Spanish kept just as alive as English.

### **Move & Play**

#### FINLAND METHOD

The base layer. Outdoors daily, movement woven through the day, and a nightly read-aloud together. This is non-negotiable, not optional.

## THE SKELETON

# A week that still feels like summer

### Morning sprint

**30–45 min · ~4 days.** Pick ONE thread for the day (rotate). Short, fresh, done before he tires.

### Build time

**2–3 sessions/week.** The game project. Counts as art + math + writing + engineering all together.

### Every day

**His activities + free play + outdoors.** Drums / hip hop / swim / taekwondo and a big block of unstructured play.

### Bedtime

**Read-aloud together.** Keep the Super Sons omnibus going + the week's stretch book. A few nights a week, read in Spanish.

## THE MISSION

# 7 weeks, one game, from idea to "I made this"

### WEEK 1

## Inventors' Workshop

Low pressure. Just dream and make.

#### MAKE & BUILD

Dream up the game. Pick the theme (symbiotes? Super Sons? his own heroes). Sketch & paint the board and a few cards.

#### LEGO MATH

Part-whole with bricks: "You have 12, give me 5 — show me what's left, then say the number."

#### CODING

**The Sandwich Robot.** He gives you exact steps to make a sandwich; you follow them too literally. That's debugging.

#### READING

Pick the summer stretch book. After each book, he draws one comic panel of his favorite moment.

### WEEK 2

## The Rulebook

Turn the idea into a real game.

#### MAKE & BUILD

Write the rules together (you scribe, he decides). Choose the playing pieces — Lego minifigs make great tokens.

#### LEGO MATH

Dice + counting spaces. Roll 20 times, tally the results: "Which number showed up most?"

#### CODING

Arrow mazes on paper. He "programs" a path (up, up, right, right) for you to walk. Intro to sequences & loops.

#### READING

**Spanish anchor.** Read in Spanish (keep Tipos Malos going) and draw a panel in Spanish.

**WEEK 5****Playtest & Fix**

The most important week. Version 1 is never the final version.

 **MAKE & BUILD**

Play the game as a family. Find what's broken or boring. Change it together — make **Version 2**.

 **LEGO MATH**

Scoring with bricks: stack each player's points. "Who has more? By how many?" (That's a bar model.)

 **CODING**

**Find the Bug.** Give him a silly broken instruction set ("brush teeth with shoe") — he spots & fixes the error.

 **READING**

Read-aloud + pause to predict: "What do you think happens next, and why?" (Comprehension, not a quiz.)

**WEEK 4****Hello, Screen**

Take the paper game digital.

 **MAKE & BUILD**

Open **ScratchJr** **FREE · iPad/Android** and start rebuilding the game. First goal: make a character move.

 **LEGO MATH**

"Groups of" — build 3 piles of 4 bricks, count the total. The quiet beginning of multiplication.

 **CODING**

ScratchJr basics: move a sprite, make it react to a tap. The unplugged ideas now run on a screen.

 **READING**

He writes & draws his own one-page comic (Cat Kid Comic Club is the perfect model — it teaches kids to make their own).

**WEEK 5****Make It Move**

Add interaction. Make it feel like a real game.

 **MAKE & BUILD**

In ScratchJr: tap to make something happen, then add a second character that responds. A tiny living world.

 **LEGO MATH**

Measure & build to target: "Make a tower exactly 10 bricks. Now one that's 3 taller."

 **CODING**

Events + **repeat** (loops). If he's flying, peek at full **Scratch** in a browser together — his reading is ready for it.

 **READING**

Label his game or comic in **both languages** — every character or button gets an EN and an ES name.

**WEEK 6****Director's Chair**

His pick. This is the Finland move — let curiosity drive.

 **MAKE & BUILD**

**He chooses** where to go deeper: more art, more code, a giant Lego build with a story, or a stop-motion movie.

 **LEGO MATH**

Real-world math he picks: cooking (fractions you can taste) or a pretend store with coins and change.

 **CODING**

Finish one small, fully playable thing in ScratchJr or Scratch — start to end, his own idea.

 **READING**

Flip it: **he reads to you**. Reading aloud builds fluency and confidence. Cheer, don't correct.

**WEEK 7****Showcase & Ship**

The payoff. He holds the thing he dreamed up.

**MAKE & BUILD**

Finalize both versions. **Family game night using HIS game** — he teaches everyone the rules (hello, confidence).

**LEGO MATH**

He's the official scorekeeper for game night — tallying, comparing, adding points for real stakes.

**CODING**

He demos the ScratchJr version. Then ask the magic question: "What would **Version 3** be?" Keep the loop open.

**READING**

Finish the stretch book and let him pick the next one — the first rung of the school-year ladder.

**SUPPLIES****Toolkit & the reading ladder****What to grab****YOU ALREADY OWN**

- › The Lego sets (your #1 math & coding tool)
- › Paper, dice, markers, paints

**FOR THE SCREEN WEEKS (4–7)**

- › **ScratchJr** — free app, iPad or Android tablet, ages 5–7, no reading needed
- › **Scratch** — free, in a browser, for when he's ready to stretch up

**COSTS NOTHING**

- › The Sandwich Robot, arrow mazes, Lego-by-instruction — all free, all screen-free

**The reading ladder****ENGLISH — STRETCH, BUT AIMED AT HIS AGE**

- › Cat Kid Comic Club — teaches kids to make their own comics
- › Hilda · The InvestiGators · Dog Man
- › Read-alouds: The Wild Robot, Mercy Watson

**ESPAÑOL — KEEP IT JUST AS ALIVE**

- › Keep going with Tipos Malos
- › Geronimo Stilton & La casa del árbol (in both languages — bounce between them)
- › El Capitán Calzoncillos

**THE PRINCIPLE**

- › Go **deeper & wider**, not faster. Enrichment beats acceleration.

***"If you can dream it,  
you can build it."***

When the summer ends, don't stop the engine — just keep one project and one stretch book always going. Next up could be a stop-motion Lego film, a real comic he writes and draws, or a bigger Scratch game. Same loop, forever: dream it, build it, test it, fix it, ship it.